From the Folder of Statements to the Decision Letter

A plain-language guide to the stages of Mom's Medicaid application.

People say “apply for Medicaid” as if it were one form. You've seen the folder on the table, and it looks like more than one form. It is. An application has stages, and it carries on after the form is sent, all while Mom's care and the decisions about it go on.

This guide walks through the stages in general terms, from the folder on the table to the decision letter, so you can see what each one involves and where your family's part sits. It explains. It doesn't say when Mom should apply or how the rules work in her state.

Before anything is sent: whose program it is, and the timing question

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program, and the states operate it day to day, including taking applications and deciding who is eligible. Within broad federal guidelines, each state decides how to run its own program. So Mom's application goes to an agency in her state, and how the rules work for her depends on that state. [1] [2]

The rules also move. The National Institute on Aging notes that benefits and eligibility requirements can change over time and differ from state to state, and suggests checking with the programs directly for the most recent information. [3]

When to apply is the question families ask first, and it has no general answer. The federal long-term care site says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances. That makes it a question for your Medicaid planner, who can look at all three for Mom. [1]

- Write the timing question down as you'd ask it: “When should Mom's application go in, and what should be ready first?”
- Add two more for the same conversation: which Medicaid program and application fit Mom, and where and how it is submitted.

Building the file: what a state may ask to see

Applying means filling out an application form and providing documentation to verify what the federal long-term care site calls the general and the financial requirements. For long-term care there is a third part, a look at the person's care needs. [1] [4]

What is required depends on the state. USA.gov's list of things an agency may ask for includes a name and date of birth, a Social Security number, proof of citizenship or immigration status, proof of income and information about current insurance. For someone who owns a home, the federal long-term care site adds that the state may ask for papers such as a current tax bill, an appraisal and copies of the mortgage. [5] [1]

The financial history can be part of it. The same federal page says that if the value of a person's assets went down a lot in the years before applying, the state may ask what happened to them. Which records Mom's state asks for, and how far back, is for your Medicaid planner to say. [1]

- Sort what you have under plain headings: identity and residency, income, bank accounts, investments and retirement, insurance, real estate, trusts and annuities, care and facility information.
- List what you haven't found, by name. A named gap is easier to fill.
- Mark large or unusual deposits, withdrawals and transfers as questions, with the date and the amount as shown. Don't decide what they mean, and don't change anything on your own.

Completing and sending it

A person may apply themselves or designate someone else, such as a family member, an attorney or a friend, to apply for them. The federal long-term care site says that person should be familiar with the situation, be able to answer the eligibility questions and have access to the financial records. [1]

The application goes to the state's Medicaid agency. Medicaid.gov keeps a state-by-state directory of the contact information for getting started. [6]

On this roadmap the form isn't something a family completes alone. Your Medicaid planner confirms the program, where and how to apply and the target date with you, and an applications specialist assembles the file, checks the answers against the supporting documents and submits it.

- When something is sent, write down what went, the date, how it was sent and by whom.
- Keep whatever shows it was sent or received, and any case or application number you're given.
- Keep a copy of everything that goes in.

After it's sent: requests, and the decision letter

The state may come back and ask for more. The federal long-term care site notes that it may take longer for the state to determine eligibility when required documents aren't provided on time, which is the reason to keep one log of what has been asked for and what has been sent. [1]

If a letter asks for something, copy what it asks for and any date it states onto the log, in the letter's own words, and take it to your Medicaid planner. What a notice means and how to answer it isn't something to work out alone.

The decision arrives by letter. An approval letter gives the date of eligibility and the amount the person must pay toward the cost of their care. A denial letter explains the reason and how to appeal, and states must give people the opportunity to request a fair hearing. [1] [7]

Either letter goes to your Medicaid planner to review with you. If it raises a legal question, that belongs to an elder law attorney; among the things the federal long-term care site says elder law attorneys do is exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid and, if appropriate, applying on their behalf. [8]

What this means for your family

- “Apply for Medicaid” becomes four stages: the questions before anything is sent, building the file, completing and sending it, and what comes back.
- Your family's part in every stage is the paper and the record: gather, sort, list what's missing, and log what is sent and asked for.
- The questions with no general answer (when to apply, which program, how far back the records go, what a letter means) go to your Medicaid planner, who knows your state.
- Knowing the stages doesn't tell you how Mom's application will go. It tells you what to have in hand at each one.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say when Mom should apply, what her state requires, how any record is treated or whether she may qualify for anything, and it doesn't suggest doing anything with her money or property. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. The general statements come from the sources below. The advice about what to write down is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You know the stages an application goes through and where your family's part sits in each. The planning interview asks about your family's situation one question at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication), Medicaid: Getting Started
3. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care
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